the possibility of a military coup has been raised—but only with a smile."[3] It never happened, and no one seriously expects that it will. But the sentiment was telling. Lieberman, a brash right-wing populist with no real military experience, was a sort of spearhead for an attack on the army's inner sanctum.

These are imperfect analogies, of course. The Ottoman Empire and the Soviet Union were both sprawling superpowers humbled by collapse; Ataturk and Putin picked up the pieces. The Jewish people were a weak and scattered diaspora. Connecting all three, though, is a mutual sense of humiliation: Russians by the West; Turks by the army, the nationalist elite, and the Allied powers who carved up the Ottoman Empire after World War I; and Jews by many cultures. All three leaders wrap themselves in the glories of the past, whether a bygone Biblical kingdom, a romanticized empire, or the mighty tsars. And all three promote religion (Russian Orthodoxy, Sunni Islam, and Judaism) as a way to stitch together a diverse and fractious society.

Europeans have a jaundiced view of nationalism because of their history. Long experience suggests that it leads to catastrophic wars and the collapse of the continent, and so a sense of shared identity is seen as a bulwark against disaster. In other places, though, nationalism appears the only way to hold together diverse groups of people. Russia has a number of autonomous regions that do not see themselves as fully Russian, while Turkey has the Kurds, who have fought a decades-long battle against the state. And in greater Israel, of course, a majority of the Jewish state's population is non-Jewish. In contrast to Europe, all three countries share a belief that, without nationalism, their states would literally cease to exist.

None of this is to suggest that the practice of politics in Israel is identical to that in Turkey or Russia. Needless to say, a vast gulf separates Israel from places where opposition voices are jailed or murdered and the security services violently intervene in politics. But one of the lessons of 2016 is that even seemingly solid democracies can be built on shaky foundations. In a number of ways, Netanyahu and his allies have already chipped away at Israel's institutions: through growing control over the media, efforts to sideline the foreign ministry and silence dissent within the army. There has also been open contempt for the Supreme Court, and rhetoric that casts principled critics as unpatriotic traitors.